

The Indie Founder Survival Guide: Emotional Fluidity

SONDIM | FOUNDER COACHING

Emotional Fluidity: What this means (and what most people miss)

Emotional fluidity is your ability to feel and welcome the full range of your emotions without resisting them. Learning to identify and actually feel your emotions in your body, rather than just talking or thinking about them, is life-changing. Indicators of repressing an emotion include looping thoughts, judging others harshly for expressing that emotion, binary decisions or feeling stuck, and perceiving yourself as better or worse than others.

Emotions aren't the problem; the resistance to them is what hurts. We often believe it's not okay to feel emotions and fear losing control. We worry sadness will last forever, fear will make us less capable, and anger means we are bad. However, resisting fear creates chronic anxiety and overthinking. Resisting sadness leads to numbness, doubt, and losing touch with what matters. Resisting anger creates stuckness, self-criticism, passivity, and depression. The key is learning to feel and move emotions in a healthy way. Emotions are simply messengers, and listening to them leads to joy, resilience, and ease.

What it feels like when you're resisting or avoiding emotions

Your responses suggest you sometimes manage or analyze your emotions instead of feeling them in your body. This avoidance can show up as worry, anxiety, or overthinking instead of the underlying emotions. Decisions stall in analysis, signaling an unfelt emotion

beneath the surface. Emotions go unrecognized until they affect your mood, behavior, or health.

You might notice feeling stressed, but struggle to let in deeper feelings like fear, sadness, or anger. You resist, shame, or avoid negative emotions because they feel uncomfortable. Deep joy is hard to access without helpers like alcohol or screens, or peak experiences like vacations. At work, you perform well but end up depleted or wired at night. Deepening emotional fluidity helps you make clearer decisions, bounce back faster, feel more joy, and overthink less. Take it easy as you explore; the goal is to understand and experience yourself, not fix yourself.

Patterns to Explore

- **Stuck in a decision = avoided feeling:** Notice when you're looping on a choice – weighing pros and cons, procrastinating, feeling analysis paralysis. The real issue may not be logic or more data. Often, there's an emotion under the surface that hasn't been felt yet. Giving space to the emotion can clarify the next step.
- **You can't diminish "pain" without diminishing joy:** Unfortunately, you can't selectively numb or shut out emotions. Welcoming hard emotions allows desired emotions like joy, love, or excitement to flow naturally.
- **Shame locks your habits:** You might think a habit will change if you're hard enough on yourself, but often, it's the shame about the habit that makes it so sticky. "Shame is the lock that holds the chains of bad habits in place". Shame embeds the pattern in your identity and leads to avoiding feelings. Feeling the habit and its discomfort allows you to drop it.

One experiment for you to try this week

1. **Option 1:** Set a reminder 10 times a day to name what you're feeling in your body. If you can identify the emotion, write it down. If not, describe the bodily sensations.

2. **Option 2:** Learn to spot avoided emotions by thinking of 5 recent judgments you've had. Complete the sentence: "If I couldn't judge [person] for [action] , I would feel [emotion]".